

Fake customer support on WhatsApp

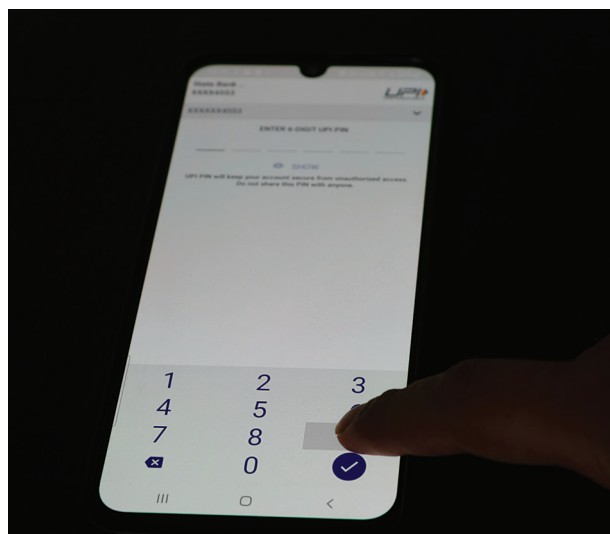
Fraudsters often impersonate customer service representatives of popular payment apps like Google Pay, PhonePe, and Paytm. They contact victims through WhatsApp, Telegram, or even regular phone calls, claiming that there is an issue with their payment account.

These scammers use social engineering tactics, pretending to help users with refund issues, failed transactions, or account verification. Under the guise of assisting, they trick users into sharing confidential details such as UPI PINs, OTPs, or even install remote access software, giving them full control over the victim's device.

A study by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) found that nearly 60% of reported digital fraud cases in 2023 involved impersonation scams, including fake customer support frauds.

Requests for UPI PIN or OTP under false pretenses

Many scams rely on social engineering to manipulate victims into revealing their UPI PIN or OTP. Fraudsters may pose as bank officials, online shopping representatives, or even law enforcement authorities, coercing users into providing sensitive details.

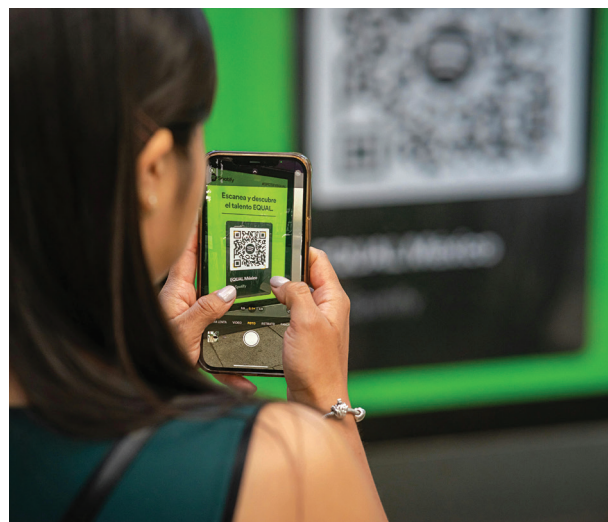


One common trick involves telling users they need to verify their UPI account to avoid deactivation. Victims, fearing loss of access to their digital wallets, end up providing their PIN or OTP, leading to unauthorized transactions draining their accounts.

According to RBI's annual fraud report, OTP frauds accounted for 30% of digital payment scams in 2023, with losses running into hundreds of crores.

QR code scams that deduct money instead of receiving payments

Scammers have exploited the widespread use of QR codes for



digital payments. In many cases, fraudsters posing as sellers send a QR code to potential buyers, claiming that scanning it will complete the payment. However, these QR codes are cleverly designed to deduct money from the victim's account rather than crediting it.

Another variation involves fraudulent QR codes posted on websites or sent via SMS and email, luring users with cashback offers or lottery winnings. Once scanned, these codes initiate unauthorized transactions, leading to financial loss.

Recent statistics from NPCI indicate that over 20,000 QR code-related fraud cases were reported in 2023 alone, highlighting the increasing prevalence of this scam.

Red flags to watch for

While digital payment fraudsters use sophisticated techniques, there are clear warning signs that users should be aware of:

Customer support contacts via social media

Legitimate companies never reach out to customers for sensitive information via WhatsApp, Telegram, or social media platforms. Any unsolicited message or call from someone claiming to be customer support should be treated with extreme suspicion. Users should always verify support numbers from official websites.

Unexpected refund requests requiring "Verification"

Fraudsters often pretend to initiate a refund for a failed transaction but claim that verification is needed. They may ask the user to share their UPI PIN or OTP to process the refund. In reality, they use this information to authorize a debit transaction instead.

Requests to scan QR codes from unknown sources

Users should never scan QR codes received from unknown individuals or unverified sources. QR codes should only be scanned